



theWindow

THE NEWSLETTER OF CHRIST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH, NEW HAVEN. VOLUME 2, ISSUE 3. FALL 2000.

A New Perspective

BY PRESTON GRAHAM



from the Pastor

I need to make a confession. As I got on the plane to return home after the PCA General Assembly, a feeling of despair came over me right when I should have expected a feeling of relief. GA, although significantly rewarding in the end, had been work intensive and at times even exhausting. And what awaited me at home was nothing

less than my three loving children and some rest, not to mention a dog, a hedgehog and a rat (alias guinea pig). So why was I feeling this way? After privately contemplating this for a time some 30,000 feet above land, I finally turned to Lisa and admitted my feelings to her. What is it, I wondered out loud? I love our home, I love the people of our church, our family is happy living in greater New Haven, I love the geography, the culture, the history, even the city itself. Moreover, I feel very blessed to work with a Session that I believe in and who experience together a great sense of camaraderie in the Lord. So why the pit in my stomach? Why was I being tempted with thoughts of change?

Finally, it dawned upon me. I felt stuck! My guess is that you know something about all the emotions that can be packed into that word. For me, it looked something like this—I felt “stuck” in a job description that, because it was a church plant in a frontier region,

seemed excessively crowded with things not directly related to the pastoral ministry as I had once envisioned it. I felt “stuck” in a kind of New England “soil” not exactly fertile for a thriving PCA presence. Most of all, I felt “stuck” in a pattern of ministry that really didn’t fit my vision for pastoral ministry. I was, to put it bluntly, horrified to discover that certain elements were lacking in my ministry that I was not very proud of.

Let me explain. As I ran into people at GA that I had once been privileged to pastor/evangelize before I moved north, God affirmed in some very powerful ways how He had been pleased to produce signifi-

cant spiritual fruit in their lives. This growth happened through various mentorship contexts in which God’s word was brought into the lives of people so that modeling, prayer, accountability, and spiritual support could be implemented in personal ways. I felt as though in New Haven I was stuck with too many other things to do than to be a good pastor/mentor/evangelist.

I think you get the point. My first impulse in response to the pit in my stomach was, “Perhaps I need a change”—a change in vocation maybe, or simply location or region. You name it, something “outside” of myself needed to change—at least this was my first impulse. But why should THIS be my first thought? Why would I look outward instead of inward about my discontent? Sure, I could disguise it all with a well thought-out veneer about vocation and calling. But at least on one level, the culprit was exposed. What I really wanted was for
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What Is a Christian Composer?

BY DANIEL KELLOGG



Perspectives

By way of introduction, my name is Daniel Kellogg and I grew up in Connecticut. My wife is Hsing-ay Hsu Kellogg; she grew up in Beijing, China, immigrated at age eight, and then lived in New Jersey and New York City. We were married in May of 1999 and moved to New Haven to attend the Yale School of Music. We began attending CPC a year ago.

I am a composer who writes music for the concert hall. I write music for string quartets, orchestras, soloists, concert bands, choirs, and chamber ensembles, all to be performed and heard in a concert setting in the tradition of classical music. Although many “classical” composers teach, I am hoping to work primarily as a freelance composer. That means I will earn my living through commissions for pieces, royalties from performances, awards or grants, and the sale of my music to various performing ensembles.

Although I am still in school, my life is much as it will be when I am out of school. Most of

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Glimpses from General Assembly 2000

BY LISA GRAHAM



Briefings

"Rock of Ages, cleft for me, let me hide myself in Thee . . ." Imagine singing these words with over a thousand other voices inside a crowded convention hall. In the middle of this hymn I was moved to contemplate how wonderful heaven will be as we all join in one voice to praise our Lord. The two-hour opening worship service for the General Assembly was definitely a highlight of the week.

Mealtimes were rich in fellowship as we were able to converse with many church planters from around the country. I was deeply challenged and encouraged as Preston and his colleagues poured out their hearts and shared their vision for reaching non-Christians through strategic church planting efforts—including one in the inner city of New Orleans, a first attempt in the state of Maine, and a project that hopes to reach the

rich and famous in posh California suburbs. I felt privileged to be a "fly on the wall" as these men bounced around many ideas among themselves.

My greatest joy was being able to sit under teaching and encouragement from several "older" women. Susan Hunt, a PCA minister's wife and author gave a seminar entitled "Your Home—A Place of Grace." She expressed her concern regarding the current trend toward Christian families "becoming an island in and of themselves" leading to isolation and detachment from "the family of all families—the church." Leading us through the scriptures, she reminded us of our Biblical responsibility to exist within the realm of the covenant community rather than falling into individualism and autonomy. Susan concluded her talk by stressing the value of acceptance versus tolerance in extending grace and love as a church. Her final exhortation was to ask our own church-

es, "Are we a safe place for families to come?" More specifically, would we be willing to have a "messy" looking youth group in order to reach families for Christ?

You might consider attending a General Assembly in the future. You would be encouraged to see the strength of the PCA as a denomination across our country. I personally left with thankfulness in my heart for the many teaching and ruling elders who poured countless hours of labor into running this GA in Tampa. Their work in committees, gracious deliberation on the floor, and love for Christ were an inspiration to me as a visitor observing their thoughts, care, and oversight. Catching a vision for what God is doing outside of our New Haven community would be a blessing for any individual or family.

Lisa Graham is the wife of Preston Graham and the mother of Anna, Nathan and Stephen.

Composer

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daily life is dedicated to writing. This means that I sit in my studio with a desk, piano, and computer and play around with notes. I construct melodies, harmonies, rhythms, forms, textures, and colors that all go together to create a piece of music that is meant to be heard as one would view a painting in a museum. Writing music is a slow process, and I may spend many months on one piece. In addition to the creative process, I prepare and print the scores and parts and take care of professional needs.

The Westminster Shorter Catechism states, "Man's chief end is to glorify God, and to enjoy him forever." I feel strongly that music and all the arts are a gift from God. They are part of the beauty and complexity of his creation, and all artists are essentially

offering humanity a glimpse of the beauty and richness of God. Ideally I hope to create music that will move people to feel something that could only come from God. I want people to enjoy God through my music and to have a desire to know God.

All artists create art out of their life experiences and their reactions to those experiences. Since God is sovereign over all things, all artists are essentially creating art in response to God. Most artists do not know God through his Word; they respond blindly. I can respond to God with the knowledge of his Word and his redemptive works. This makes a tremendous difference. I can read the psalms and find every possible human emotion in every possible extreme. I can read Revelation and see the most violent horrible battles and the most incredible act of mercy and love. When I write, I can respond to these things with first-hand knowledge and real belief.

Sometimes when I write a piece, I think how joyous it is to dance before the Lord in sheer delight, or how much our sin distances us from our Father and causes pain and suffering, or how beautiful and majestic is the world he has created. Everything worth saying in art comes from God, and as an artist I can learn and live this through God and express it through the gifts He has given me.

Often my music is directly based on a

Christian theme. In the case of choral music, I write music to express and illuminate a passage of scripture. With instrumental music, I also try to express an idea in scripture but in a more abstract way. When I write music based on secular themes, my relationship with God through Christ still shapes my work.

Whatever piece I am working on, I strive for excellence and pray for help. I try hard to carry the love of Jesus into all professional situations and to view composing as a service to the community. In this highly competitive and diminishing field, I am frequently tempted to be jealous of my colleagues' successes, making music into an idol and engaging in gossip or dirty politics. If I didn't know the gospel, I would drown in these sins. As a Christian I am blessed to see these sins clearly so that I may fight them and ask God for help and forgiveness. I also know that no matter what success I may enjoy through my work, all things pale in comparison to the sacrifice of Christ.

Perhaps the greatest comfort in being a Christian composer is knowing that God is sovereign. I believe that He called me to compose, and I humbly trust that He will use my labors for His glory.

Daniel Kellogg is a composition student at the Yale School of Music.



Member Myron Kwong and Associate Pastor Tom Morrison mingle with two visitors.

New Perspective

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“it” to be “easier.” And once named, it needed rebuking. For where does the Bible call us to something merely because it’s “easier?” How does this fit the call to “take up your cross and follow after me?”

And then it hit me as, still 30,000 feet in the air, I turned to Lisa with this thought. What if I were to fly into New Haven as if I were a candidate for my own job? What would I see if I had never been here as the church planter? (A new perspective—hmmm!) Answer: I would be generally encouraged about a whole host of things, not least of which was that much of the “soil preparation” needing to happen in a frontier context had already been done. (What? Did I really believe this?) It was true, several “networks” had already been formed and were in their early stages that would facilitate a wider PCA presence in New Haven. A strong church organization already existed with a solid training program for leaders. The church already had a perfect location for long-term strategic presence in greater New Haven. An “establishment feeling” historic building for a study center already existed, and a new worship center was soon to be completed. The needed income for the building was all but established through a Christian daycare center that would also serve as an outreach opportunity. A restructured Presbytery was in place that was poised as a network for all sorts of ministry and church planting cooperatives, etc. So what would I see as the real need at CPC, and was this something I felt called to do? In short, I would conclude that while the first two marks of the church as evidenced through word and sacrament were relatively strong, the third mark as demonstrated through mentorship/discipleship was relatively weak. And guess what? This was exactly what I most felt called to do! So what needed changing? Not my outward circumstances, but my inward priorities and perspective. The moment I looked at my trip to New Haven from a new perspective, the pit in my stomach left almost immediately.

OK, you ask, why do you tell us this? It’s simple. First, I wanted to let you know what I perceive to be the “state of the church” so that we can direct our priorities in the coming year(s). Lisa and I both look forward to implementing a greater emphasis on spiritual “fathering/mothering.” In seven plus years, God has been pleased to do many great things in our midst upon which we can build.



Heather Hawkes, Josh Kebabian and Nathan Graham work on a project in Sunday School.

But more to the point, I believe it is important to be “real” with you and let you in on my own struggles as your Christian brother. I believe that even the importance and unique quality of the pastoral relationship with the flock of God should not usurp the prior relationship of brother to brother/sister between “co-Christians.” I see Paul often relating to his congregations not only as their pastor, but also as their brother at times, and often a struggling brother at that. But he did this by way of encouragement, exhorting his brothers and sisters to press on to know Christ (Phil. 1: 1-14). So I share all this with you so that if you can relate to my own struggles, you will be encouraged to know Christ all the more.

All too often, we feel “stuck” in a pattern of life that we can’t see a way out of except by changing the outward circumstances. Without transcendent values with which to inform our perspective, we too often think that to get “un-stuck” we must change mates, jobs, churches, houses, cars, or some other outward thing. It’s interesting that Paul discovered that he did not need to change his outward circumstances to change his discontent, but rather his inward expectations and his perspective on his vocational/personal goals. He learned that he could be content in whatever circumstances God ordained for him. Why? Because the outward circumstances really weren’t the culprit after all, at least not usually. It was something else that needed changing. Even when in jail, Paul adapted his vision to God’s providence and worked within the context God had placed him in, as he explains in his letter to the

Philippians.

I am amazed at how often we are exhorted to perseverance within our calling in the NT. Paul exhorts the new convert not to leave his job and the believing spouse not to leave his/her unbelieving spouse except for very limited reasons (1 Cor. 7). Why? Because the overarching theme of the early church fathers may be summed up “But seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things shall be added to you (Matt. 6: 33). Our first impulse as Christians then ought not to be “I need a change,” but rather “How can I best serve the kingdom of God given the providence of God as I know it? How can I be most useful to God for the sake of his kingdom?” (Notice from the context of Matthew 6 the kinds of anxieties that ought not to drive us.) Once we determine what best serves the Kingdom of God, we can heed the encouragement of John writing to a people who would have every reason to feel “stuck” in outward circumstances. He says, “Here is a call for the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and hold fast to the faith of Jesus (Rev. 14:12). So don’t allow your outward circumstances to hinder or discourage you—work with God’s providence for his glory, and be encouraged!

Far from feeling “stuck,” I can honestly say that I am enthusiastic about the continued privilege of co-laboring with you in Greater New Haven for the Kingdom of God!

Preston Graham is the Pastor of Christ Presbyterian Church.



Timothy Cheng, son of Jennifer and Shi-jen, plays at the beach this summer.



theWindow

Editor Katie Levesque

Graphic Designer Mihira Jayasekera

Website Designer Mary Smith



FALL CALENDAR COMING SOON!



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135 Whitney Avenue, New Haven, CT 06510